Day 6 — The Modern Lens

Module: Pañcabhūta (Senior) · **Time:** 45 min

Learning objective

Students identify three things modern science *adds* to the picture that Sāṅkhya does not have, and three things Sāṅkhya *includes* that modern science explicitly excludes.

Materials

- Periodic table poster
- NCERT Class 11 Chemistry, Chapter 1 (atomic structure) — printed extract
- Whiteboard

Flow

Warm-up (5 min)

- Hand back yesterday's quiz. Brief review of common errors.

Core (25 min)

1. **What modern science adds:**
    - **Atomic structure** — protons, neutrons, electrons. The periodic table's 118 elements are atom-based, not state-of-matter-based.
    - **Predictive chemistry** — combinations follow rules (valence, electronegativity) we can calculate.
    - **Subatomic and field-level descriptions** — quarks, electromagnetic field, weak and strong forces. None of this is in Sāṅkhya.
    - **Quantitative measurement** — mass, density, melting point. Sāṅkhya is qualitative.
2. **What Sāṅkhya includes that modern science explicitly excludes:**
    - **Empty space (*ākāśa*) as a category** — modern physics treats vacuum as the absence of matter, not as a distinct category.
    - **A perceptual mapping** — *tanmātra-indriya* one-to-one symmetry. Modern science treats perception as biology (neuroscience), not as a metaphysical layer.
    - **Consciousness in the scheme** — *puruṣa* (the witness) is part of the 25-tattva enumeration. Modern science either bracket consciousness (default in chemistry) or treats it as emergent from matter (in some neuroscience interpretations).
3. **The honest framing:** these are different KINDS of inquiry, not different *qualities* of inquiry.

Inquiry	Modern science	Sāṅkhya
"What predicts	Strong	Weak

Inquiry	Modern science	Sāṅkhya
chemical behaviour?”		
“What categories does the everyday world come in?”	Decent (states of matter)	Strong
“How does perception fit with reality?”	Modern: neuroscience; not in chemistry	Strong (tanmātra–indriya)
“Where does consciousness fit?”	Mostly bracketed	Central (puruṣa)

Reflection writing (10 min)

5-minute quick-write: *“For one question above where Sāṅkhya is ‘Strong’ but modern science is ‘Mostly bracketed’ or ‘Weak,’ do you think this is a real intellectual asset of the Sāṅkhya scheme, or a leftover of pre-scientific guessing? Defend your position in 4–5 sentences.”*

Discussion (5 min)

3 students share their position. Note the diversity of views.

Wrap-up (5 min)

- Preview Day 7: *“Tomorrow — group debate. Should IKS be integrated into mainstream science class?”*

Differentiation

- **Tier up:** Read Thomas Nagel’s “What Is It Like to Be a Bat?” — write 1 paragraph on whether Sāṅkhya’s tanmātra-indriya symmetry maps onto Nagel’s “subjective experience” question.
- **Tier down:** Stick to the comparison table; the quick-write can be 2–3 sentences.

Teacher notes

- Push students past “old vs new” framing into “different scopes, different methods.”
- Some students may genuinely believe consciousness is “just neurons” — that’s a defensible position. Some may believe it’s irreducible. Both are taken seriously in contemporary philosophy of mind; the module shouldn’t decide for them.

Citation(s) used

- NCERT Class 11 Chemistry, Chapter 1.
- (Optional) Nagel, T. (1974). “What Is It Like to Be a Bat?” *Philosophical Review*, 83(4), 435–450.